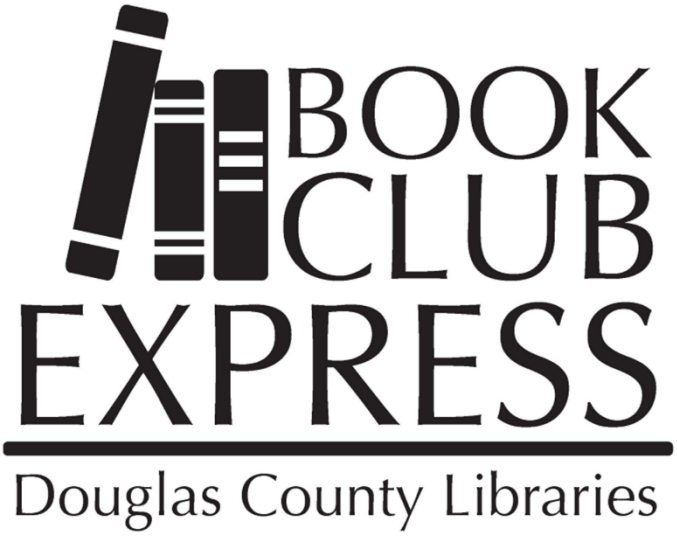

The Quiet Librarian
by Allen Eskens

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Discussion Questions

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Discussion Questions

1. Before reading The Quiet Librarian, what did you know or remember about the war in Bosnia?

2. How does the blue marble act as a thread connecting various aspects of the two plot lines?

3. In Chapter 22, Nura makes a decision while fighting on the side of a mountain. If you had been in her shoes, would you have made the same decision? If not, what would you have done?

4. Babo tells Hana that men have the capacity for good as much as they have the capacity for cruelty. What is right and what is wrong is written on our hearts, but when there is war, men follow what they choose to follow and rationalize the evil they do. Are there parallels to this sentiment in any present-day circumstances?

5. How did Hana and Amina deal with their trauma differently?

6. Should David Claypool have turned in his badge at the end of the story?

7. Do you know anyone in your life that lives a quiet life but has an incredible past?

8. Would you consider this book to be historical fiction, mystery, thriller, or something else?

9. Would you like to see a future book that revolves around the characters from this novel, or do you think this is the end of Hana's story? If you think another story would be good, whose story and why?

From: https://alleneskens.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/03/Quiet-Librarian-book-club-questions.pdf

Author Interview

STEVE THOMAS: Allen, welcome to the show.

ALLEN ESKENS: I'm glad to be here. Thanks for having me.

ST: Before we get into the book, can you tell me a little bit about your personal experience with libraries either as a kid or now as an author or both?

AE: Yes, I think you're gonna find that my answer to this question is different than most. I don't recall going to a public library until I was in high school. I did not come from a family of readers. We didn't have a bunch of books at home. My parents didn't read to me that I recall, and so I didn't grow up reading. And in fact, I always struggled with reading all my life. I can remember in first grade, reading aloud for that 1st time and realizing that I was the 2nd slowest reader in my class, and I was paralyzed with fear because I thought I was gonna get held back.

And so I really didn't spend time in libraries, but my life changed. When I got into high school, I actually vowed that I was going to do nothing extracurricular. I was the kid that your parents didn't want you to hang around with, and my best friend and I kind of dared each other to try out for the school play, which was called Oklahoma. I'd never heard of Oklahoma. I'd never seen a musical. I had no idea what I was getting myself into, but we tried out, we got in, and I had a great time. I fell in love with theater and that's when I discovered the public library because the public library had an enormous collection of albums, and I would go there and I was introduced to Sondheim, you know, Company, I was introduced to The Fantasticks, to Chorus Line, and I was checking out show tune albums as fast as I could and memorizing the songs.

It was my love of theater that propelled me to go to college. I wanted to keep doing theater. So I thought if I went to college, I could do theater. Got into college, found out that I could get around my issues with reading and turned out I graduated with a degree in journalism, went to law school, got my law degree, practiced law for 25 years, but I wanted to do something creative to scratch that itch that I had developed in theater, so that's when I started writing.

And I wrote just for my own fun, just my own enjoyment. And when my first book, my debut novel came out, The Life We Bury, the very first bit of buzz came from the American Library Association. And I was incredibly excited. And then I would go online, and Google "The Life We Bury" and "library" just to see what new libraries were picking it up and putting it on the shelf after it came out. And now one of my favorite things in the world is to do library events. Minnesota has a wonderful library system, and they have grant programs that can bring in authors, and I have done hundreds of library events and I'm able to go to towns where the town is nothing more than a crossroad, and there's a library there and speak and it was actually on the way to one of these library events that I came up with the idea for the novel, The Quiet Librarian.

ST: Right. And that's what mostly what we're going to talk about here today. Can you tell listeners what The Quiet Librarian is about? And do you remember what that spark was in your head when you were on that trip home of that made you think of it?

AE: I do. So I was killing time before I got in the car. It was about a two hour drive to this library, and I turned on the TV and there's this movie called The Reader. I'd seen it before so I was watching it just in the background. And the movie has a character, the main character is a middle aged woman in, I think, Western Germany after the war. And you get to know her through the eyes of this young man who's reading books to her. And for the first third of the movie, you see her a certain way and you feel an affinity toward her. And then you learn something about her, and it changes how you feel. It changes how you see her.

And I get in my car and I'm driving to this library event. I'm thinking, and I daydream, that that's really where my love of storytelling comes from. I'm a huge daydreamer. So I had this daydream. I was thinking, okay, if I were going to write a novel about a middle aged woman who had a secret past, what would it be? And by the time I got to the library event, I had a rough outline for this story and this character, and then on the drive home, I kind of finished it off and I knew what the story was going to be.

And what I knew, in part, was that it was going to be a quiet woman, unassuming, someone who kind of blends into the background, and she's fine with that. In fact, that's what she likes, who has this incredible past that nobody knows about. And so I thought, okay, what would be that catalyst, that past? And I looked, you know, what, what was going on in the world 30 years ago? Well, there was a war in Bosnia, so I decided I was going to make that her backstory. She was forged by this war. Then I started researching the war in Bosnia. Now, I was alive when the war was going on. I saw it on the news. I knew so little about that event. As I'm researching, I realized that I'd bitten off more than I can chew. That this story was, this wasn't just a backstory. What happened to her in Bosnia had to be half the story, and I also knew that I needed help. writing that part of the story.

So I reached out to the University of Minnesota and also to the Bosniak community in Minneapolis. And I got two people respond to me who grew up in Bosnia during the war, and that changed this book so much. I sat down with them, talked to them about what it was like in that time being a teenager. And I realized that this backstory had to be told with reverence, that I had to make this a historical fiction. Half a novel was gonna be historical fiction, but based as close as I could on real events or real type events. And so I spent a lot of time with these two learning what it was like to be a Muslim, to be a female Muslim, to be a Bosnian during that time. And without them, I could not have written this book. So, when you open the book up, the first thing you see is the dedication to those two people, Erma and Elvir.

ST: Yeah, and it's interesting because the main character is Muslim, but she's secular, like, they don't go to the mosque. They don't practice, but obviously within, once you learn more about

what's happening in Bosnia, you learn that that's very important, and that people don't care basically whether you're secular or super religious.

AE: No, it was truly an ethnic cleansing because Bosnia was an area where you had cities that had Serbian people in it and Muslim, and this is one of the things that Elvir pointed out. He goes, in all these wars you see, you have a country versus a country. You have Croats versus Serbians. You have Kosovo's. But in Bosnia, it was Serbian, a country, versus a people, the Muslim people, who are the Bosnians. And so it was an effort to get rid of the Muslims from the country and you had them in every city. So it wasn't just a matter of here's the border, one side's fighting the other side. It was town by town, street by street, neighbor by neighbor, and it was a very dangerous place to live.

One of the things that I learned early on was names are important. That you knew if you were Serbian or Bosnian Muslim by the name. So I had a name in there initially for one of my characters and Erma said, "You know, that that's actually a Serbian name. You would need to have a different name for that person." And so I had to be very careful with the names I chose and just the way neighbor turned on neighbor so quickly… so it was really the Serbian Belgrade government trying to get rid of the Muslim people from this area.

ST: And obviously the "quiet librarian" role is something she's constructed later in her life, but when she's younger, her whole family is trying to live this quiet life, off to the side. Her father doesn't want to get involved with the war, like, just let us live here in the mountains. We're not bothering anybody. We're not doing anything. But one of the themes of the book is that war will come for you all. You can't escape this kind of thing.

AE: Exactly. And one of the things that my character's father, he's a Mason, he just wants to build his houses and be left alone and he raises cattle and his brother says it doesn't work that way. The war will find you. And it did.

ST: And you know, we don't want to give away too many spoiler thing here, but she does eventually get more and more involved with the war because at first it's not happening at all and then Yugoslavia is breaking up and you know, I know it did happen, but it's so odd to go back and think now that the Olympics were there in just, what, 1984? Yeah, and it's like, it was stable enough to have a big international event like that, and then less than 10 years later, it's in this genocide, basically.

AE: It is. And I wanted to make sure I pointed that out in I think, like, the second and third chapter, that they had the Olympics there and they were so proud. Tito, the dictator, held that country together. When he died, everybody said, "Well, we're leaving. See ya!" And it just went into chaos. But yeah, 84, the Olympics, you had Torval and Dean skating to Bolero that became very famous, and just less than a decade later, you had massacres in Srebrenica and Tuzla and places like that.

ST: And there's that duality of her personality that she's constructed, but it was almost like a tragedy happens to her obviously early in the book and it forces a change in her. But then when she comes to the US, she constructs this other kind of identity that even so much that the kids around are just, "Oh, that's the sweater lady." She's trying to blend in and look as unassuming as possible, but it does come back to haunt her because then there's a death that once she starts investigating, she realizes may be tied into what happened in Bosnia.

AE: Yes. So story begins with her best friend falling or getting pushed from a balcony, and Hana, the quiet librarian, realizes or believes that someone from her past has come looking for her. This is not, I don't think, giving away too much of a spoiler, but she is thrust into the war, and in that role as a militia fighter, she becomes something of a legend, and she has to flee Bosnia, and she's kind of been hiding here in the U. S. when the book begins with the death of her friend.

ST: Did your does your background as a journalist or a criminal defense attorney, did that influence how you wrote this book?

AE: Probably the journalist part, just the research. My other nine books are all mystery thrillers. While this is a mystery, it is more historical fiction mystery, which is a first for me, but when I was in journalism school at the University of Minnesota, one of the things that I love the most was learning how to research. And that was before the Internet. That's how old I am. So we learned to research old school. And delving into this Bosnian war and that world, I spent a lot of time researching that to try and understand it. And it is very confusing, but I think I have a much better appreciation for it now.

ST: The book basically, it goes back and forth between chapters of Bosnia during the war and then Minnesota. Did you have to outline that out to make everything line up? Just craft-wise, how do you work that out?

AE: I'm a big outliner. I'm a big believer in outlines. And this book was a difficult book to outline. Because I didn't want to just have, story from the 90s, story from present, 90s, present, and go back and forth. I wanted to have a connection.

So what I did was I outlined the story from the past first. And I had plot points for all the things that were going to happen in the past, and I laid them out on post-it notes on a table. Then I created post-it notes for all of the plot points that I knew I needed for the present. And I just sat there and kept arranging and rearranging so that there'd be a connection. So in the past, when the character uses a knife for the first time, in the present, she goes into a pawn shop and buys a knife. And she's thinking back to that knife that she had before. And so there's a connection between chapters as I go.

And that was hard to do and it took a long time, but I have a picture on my phone. When I finally got it, I took a picture of the table with all these post-it notes just in case somebody knocked the table or scattered the post-it notes. But yeah, I'm a big believer in outlines. I can

visualize the story from beginning to end and have these plot points in front of me and I can see the whole story. Then I sit down and go to writing it.

ST: And I guess "vengeance" is the right word is a big part of the story. Did you find it hard to, when you're writing her story, she's doing a lot of very brutal things in the name of vengeance, of keeping her likeable when she's doing these horrific acts for a good reason, but you have to show that reasoning to keep her as a likable character.

AE: Yeah, so there are heroes and there are antiheroes. Antihero is someone who does a bad thing, but has a good reason behind it. So it was just a matter of creating her and letting the reader experience what she experienced so that they would then understand why she takes the steps she takes. And if the reader doesn't necessarily agree, at least they understand.

There are people that are what I call a talisman. A talisman kind of transports you from one place to another, from one time of the story to another. So in this story, when she takes over custody of her friend's grandson, that child becomes a talisman and it transports her back to those days when she had a little brother that age and all the pain that she experienced from that relationship and what happened. And now she transfers that to this new child and so again, connects the past to the present.

ST: Yeah, because a lot of her identity that she's made is to hide literally from people who are hunting her, but also almost a protective cocoon for herself as well, where she's trying to just not have to think about that past, but this brings it back into sharp relief again, where she has to confront it all again.

AE: Yeah, so her friend who died, her name's Amina. Amina also escaped Bosnia and the two have different ways of dealing with it. Amina, because she had family or a child, at least, she felt she needed to get past it. Hana, on the other hand, just walled herself off. She didn't want to get past it. She didn't want to get over because she thought if I get over it, I'm going to lose that memory and that love. And so she kind of wallows in the past for 30 years. So the story is also her dealing with having walled herself off from the world.

ST: Do you have any advice for aspiring writers who were looking at this type of story of how to tackle those both historical and emotional themes in a respectful way?

AE: Yeah. Do your research. Like I said, I was very lucky to find those two people to help me. This story would not be what it is without them. And I think back to a day when I was talking to one of my sources and the way she told her story about being pulled from school and taken to a place where she believed she was going to be executed with her other Muslim classmates, and then only to have that plan fall apart because a Spanish journalist happened to hear that something was going on and showed up. And when that Spanish journalist showed up, they took the kids back to school.

And she's telling me this story with all the calmness of me talking about having getting stung by a bee when I was a kid, and I'm just sitting there amazed. There are people in the world who have lived extraordinary lives, and the fact that I get to tell a fictional story, but one that represents their journeys, I saw that I had to write it with reverence and sincerity and authenticity.

ST: And do you think fictionalizing things like this can help readers process these kinds of issues? Like, being able to follow Hana's story here can help us number one, learn about Bosnia and also maybe process what happened there a little easier.

AE: That's one of the things that I'm seeing from the early reviews, like on Goodreads almost to a person they're saying, "I was around then I had no idea. I didn't know this stuff was going on. I learned a lot, very appreciative." So, yeah, I do think historical fiction, when you are true to what happened can be very valuable to teach lessons and teach history.

ST: Yeah, and the detective character is sort of our stand in for that kind of person who didn't, I mean, he lots of other roles he has in the book, but that's one of them is that Hana can explain things to him because he doesn't know anything about that past. You do a very good job, I think, of explaining, obviously there's much more depth to it that you could go into, but explaining the basics of what's going on there.

AE: Yeah, I focused just on the Bosnian part of it, but there was Slovenia, Croatia, Kosovo, Albania, all these other breakaways that were fighting against Belgrade, but also fighting against each other. Croatia at one point was fighting against Bosnia, but then turned around and became an ally of Bosnia, so it was very confusing. But yeah, so the detective, is really a stand in for me, my understanding of that time. I'd heard the name Milosevic, I've heard the countries of Kosovo and Croatia, but I really didn't have a good understanding of how that fell apart and how that war happened until I started doing this research.

There was a massacre that happened in Srebrenica, 8,000 men and boys, when the city fell, and one of my sources was fighting in the trenches of Srebrenica. And he saw the helicopters come in and take the generals away, so he knew the city was about to fall. So he and a friend swam the river and got into Serbia. They actually swam away from the Bosnian areas and surrendered and they were put in a prison of war camp. But when the city fell, the Serbs came in and took thousands of men and boys out to the woods and just shot them. And I was alive, and I was like, I think I have a vague recollection of something like that being talked about in the news, but yeah, it really hit home when I was doing this research.

ST: Yeah, and that's an amazing story there, too, of just the fact that they did that, escaped in that way, they're still in custody, which it wasn't a great situation, but they weren't in the city then and would have been killed at that point.

AE: And he had no idea if he was going to live or die. They swam the river, they got put into a prisoner of war camp. It was more like a prison, actual prison, he said, and every day he would wake up thinking, "Is today the day I'm going to be shot?" And then one day they came, took him out of his cell, put him in a truck and okay, he's thinking this is the end. He gets out of the truck at an airport. And they fly him back to Bosnia, and he's like, "What just happened?" He had no clue, and then that's when he found out that his friends and I think he had some cousins in Srebrenica who did not survive.

ST: Well, that's why I think it can be helpful, like that story kind of helps you understand, and then using Hana as a avatar, basically, to follow through and learn about this stuff too that's sometimes the best way to learn about this stuff.

So I did want to ask one quick, last two questions I know you said you came late to reading and such, but do you remember what the first book that you read is that you really fell in love with?

AE: Yes Where the Red Fern Grows So there's only a couple books that I read in middle school and high school that I actually read from beginning to end, and that was one of the first and I think it's because I grew up in the Ozarks. I grew up in the woods. And so I related to this kid in that book, and there's a part in the book, if you read the book, you know what I'm talking about, where you cry. And I got so angry. It's like, this is just ink on paper. Why are you crying? And so I finished the book and then a couple of weeks later, I read it again. I had never read a book twice. And I read it again just because I wanted to prove to myself that I wouldn't cry at that one point. And no, I did not succeed. I cannot read that book without getting emotional and tearing up. So that was the first time that I realized that words on paper can really have an impact even if you know it's not true.

ST: Yeah. I read Old Yeller when I was a kid and had never heard anything about what happens at the end. And so, I was like, "Whaaaat?"

AE: There should be a surgeon general warning on books like that.

ST: And then what are you reading now that you're enjoying or what's the last good thing that you read?

AE: So I just finished All the Colors of the Dark by Chris Whitaker. It's a book that takes place in Missouri, Chris Whitaker's most recent book.

ST: All right. Well thank you so much for coming on the podcast and letting us know about the book. I very much enjoyed it. I think listeners will enjoy it. And the book again, it is the Quiet Librarian. And yes, there are parts in the libraries, so library listeners, there are parts that you can read and go, "That's just like what I do!" So and it's available now. So go get a copy wherever fine books are sold or check it out at your local library, and if your local library doesn't have it, ask them to purchase it and then it's still a purchase and Alan still gets that little bit of money. So Alan, thank you so much for coming on the show.

AE: I greatly appreciate you having me. Thank you very much. It's been a pleasure.

From: https://circulatingideas.com/transcripts/allen-eskens/

Author Biography

Allen Eskens is the bestselling author of The Life We Bury, The Guise of Another, The Heavens May Fall, The Deep Dark Descending, The Shadows We Hide, Nothing More Dangerous, The Stolen Hours, Forsaken Country, Saving Emma, and his latest novel, The Quiet Librarian.

He is the recipient of the Barry Award, Minnesota Book Award, Left Coast Crime Award, and Silver Falchion Award and has been a finalist for the Edgar® Award, Thriller Award, Anthony Award and Nero Award. His books have been translated into 23 languages.

Allen has a journalism degree from the University of Minnesota and a law degree from Hamline University. After law school, he studied creative writing in the M.F.A. program at Minnesota State University-Mankato, as well as the Loft Literary Center and the Iowa Summer Writer's Festival. Allen grew up in the hills of central Missouri. He now lives with his wife, Joely, in greater Minnesota where he recently retired after practicing criminal law for 25 years.

Allen is represented by Amy Cloughley of Kimberley Cameron and Associates Literary Agency.

From: https://alleneskens.com/about-allen/

Reviews

"A searing and timely story of regret, retribution, and reinvention, set against a powerfully drawn backdrop of war and suffused with the reminder that we always have within us the power to light the way to a better tomorrow."—Kristin Harmel, New York Times bestselling author of The Paris Daughter

“This book will stay with me for a long, long time. From the very first lines, I knew I was in the hands of a master storyteller. Eskens effortlessly interweaves a compelling mystery in modern day Minnesota with a devastating account of one young girl’s experience of war thirty years prior. The novel unflinchingly urges its readers to consider the morally grey concept of retribution in light of the most terrible crimes. In stunning prose, it shows all too clearly the way war has the ability to make monsters of ordinary people and how neither side, victor or not, will be free of its poison for decades to come. Lamentably, this is all too relevant in today’s world. The Quiet Librarian is exquisitely written, profoundly affecting, and is undoubtedly one of the best books I will read this year.”—Louise Fein, author of The London Bookshop Affair

“Eskens renders a searing suspense of wartime that chronicles the loss of homeland and family, with an utterly unforgettable heroine and her heartbreaking journey for retribution. Potent and exquisitely written, The Quiet Librarian comes to life in brutal war-torn Bosnia and present-day Minnesota with a shocking conclusion that will leave you breathless."—Kim Michele Richardson, New York Times bestselling author of The Book Woman of Troublesome Creek series

"In The Quiet Librarian, Allen Eskens brings readers a suspenseful, heartrending story of friendship, strength and endurance, set against a history too rarely explored in fiction. This is a truly breathtaking read from a masterful storyteller and one I cannot recommend highly enough."—Kelly Rimmer, New York Times bestselling author of The Things We Cannot Say

"The Quiet Librarian is a devastating and engrossing novel, a breathtaking thriller that gets to the complex heart of grief, regret, and re-invention. Hana Babic is an absolutely unforgettable main character."—Lou Berney, USA Today bestselling author of Dark Ride

“Rich in detail and perfectly paced, Allen Esken’s The Quiet Librarian immerses readers in an often forgotten war, but also takes us on an emotional journey with a gutsy protagonist who is suddenly forced to step out of the shadows to settle an old score when her past unexpectedly comes calling. Mystery, history, and a kick-ass female lead—what’s not to love!?”—Barbara Davis, bestselling author of The Echo of Old Books

Read-Alikes

When the Stars Go Dark by Paula McLain
Anna Hart is a seasoned missing persons detective in San Francisco with far too much knowledge of the darkest side of human nature. When unspeakable tragedy strikes her personal life, Anna, desperate and numb, flees to the Northern California village of Mendocino. She spent summers there as a child with her beloved grandparents, and now she believes it might be the only place left for her to heal. Yet the day she arrives, she learns a local teenage girl has gone missing. Anna is in no condition to become involved with the search--until a childhood friend, now the village sheriff, pleads for her help.

Hard By A Great Forest by Leo Vadiashvili
A devastating story of one family's border-crossing adventure to rescue one another and make peace with the past, set in the former Soviet republic of Georgia, two years after the occupation of South Ossetia by Russia in 2008.